the late 1990s when it might have been possible to trace some of the families.

Edwin Samuel helped me trace the great-grandson and grandnephew of M.V. Maya Nadar, K. Nirmalavel.

The late S. Pothi Reddy, R. Pathmanabha Iyer, Steve Hughes and Sarah Hodges have helped in various ways over the years. It is my lasting regret that Bernard Bate did not live to see this book. In his last years, Barney wrote a splendid book on the history of Tamil oratory that provides deep insights into the Swadeshi days.

As an experienced marine engineer, Vinod Remesh clarified the meaning of many nautical terms.

If Vellaiyampattu Sundaram and M.D. Raju Kumar had not published my first books on VOC in my teens, I wonder who would have taken me seriously.

I warmly recall my association with the late C. Wallacewaran, VOC's last son and A. Shanmugasundaram, VOC's first grandson.

I pay homage to my earliest mentors, 'Mugam' Mamani (1931–2022) and Tha. Kovendhan (1932–2004).

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Kannan Sundaram, as friend and publisher, has been an inseparable part of my intellectual and social life over the last three decades.

Conversations with Whitney Cox, Sunil Amrith, Prashanth Kidambi, Ram Manoharan Karthick, Bhavani Raman, Francis Cody and Mahesh